

analyze your own shopping habits accordingly. Do you run to the store a couple of times a week just to get milk, only to end up spending forty dollars on things you hadn't intended on purchasing? These are the impulse buys stores count on, and you want to avoid them. Do you grab from the endcaps, assuming the sale price is a discount? Manufacturers pay for the prime spots and sometimes higher priced items are paired with the loss leaders. Don't shop blindly. Learn prices and comparison shop. Some couponers suggest making up a price book to keep track of average prices but I've found that as the primary shopper I pretty much know the average price of the products I purchase regularly. Do you shop mostly from the shelves at eye-level? Remember, lower shelves are not prime shelving. Lower shelves might mean lower prices.

Making a shopping list can just be an added chore to an already long to-do list, but anyone who wants to seriously lower their grocery bill should attempt one. The great thing about coupons is that they can actually make shopping less of a chore and more of a game: a game you can win if you plan your moves. Some general guidelines in shopping, which you may have heard a hundred times before, but that bear repeating:

Don't shop when you are hungry. It's funny how delicious that bag of chocolate-coated gourmet popcorn looks when you are ravenous, even though you'd never buy it otherwise. Impulse buys can be detrimental to both your waistline and your wallet.

Don't shop with your children. I inwardly cringe, giving that advice, since I was the mother with toddlers and babies in tow for so many years. I didn't have much choice, but if you do have a choice, choose not to bring